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BETASHARES · SYDNEY

RE: DIRECTOR, IN-HOUSE CREATIVE AGENCY · 16 SEPTEMBER 2026

Your brief asks for a demonstrated track record of building or transforming an in-house agency, not just running one. I have done it twice, in opposite conditions, and I am doing it a third time now with AI.

At PageGroup I inherited five graphic designers and rebuilt them as a full-service in-house agency: specialists by discipline plus a studio manager, across print, web, user experience, video and photography. That studio then held four brands consistent across eleven Asia Pacific markets and three audience tiers, serving candidate and employer audiences at the same time, at a cadence of over a hundred videos and roughly two thousand assets a year, and launched Thailand and Vietnam from zero. None of it arrived with new budget. **The capability was funded by efficiency taken out of repeatable production**, and delivered through a restructure I proposed and led. The team changed shape rather than simply growing, and what the business got back was disciplines the studio did not previously have. That is the closest parallel I can offer to your situation: an existing team, existing output obligations, no pause button, and a mandate to end up somewhere structurally different.

At AVJennings I did the opposite, and under harder conditions. The in-house agency started as an experiment to test whether the model could work at all, and I had twelve months to prove return on creative investment or it would not continue. So I instrumented it: hours, work type and delivered impact captured on every job, reported to the C-suite monthly for twelve months. Each quarter the data set the plan: repeatable work redesigned to take less time, some outputs rebuilt, others retired because they no longer earned their place. The released capacity went back into conceptual work. **External creative agency fees fell from \$1.5M to \$2M a year to roughly \$750K, and agency dependency went from nine agencies to three.** I owned and managed a \$1M budget across roughly twenty communities and 250 to 300 releases a year, with templates, briefing and review workflows, approval governance and asset management underneath it. The in-house agency did not serve marketing alone: it serviced Acquisitions, Corporate, Customer Service and the home and community Design team, none of whom reported to me and none of whom briefed the same way, which is the actual in-house agency problem and the one that most often sinks the model. I launched multiple project brands and rebranded large established estates along the way, each carrying masterbrand-scale demands against a release deadline. And I deliberately kept video out of house, because that work needed producers shooting on location nationally. What gets insourced is decided by the nature of the work, not by a belief that in-house is always better, and that judgment is what keeps a clean line between what the in-house agency owns and what an external agency partner should do.

On AI I would rather be precise than enthusiastic. At Tydal we built an AI-powered design system, translating brand guidelines into working design systems across several platforms, and used it to produce a full campaign on live client work, primarily digital and culminating in the social executions. Production moved from seven days to two. The honest caveat is that stakeholders and approvals do not compress at the same rate, so the end-to-end gain is smaller than the production gain. The more useful finding is that **the constraint is not the model**. What slows a pipeline down is the brief arriving unstructured, no validation of the audience, no methodology for matching the right design system to the deliverable, and no interface a non-designer can use. That is where I would spend the first ninety days, and it is measurable work rather than a tooling exercise. I disclose AI use to clients and deliberately do not market on it.

One tension in your brief is worth naming. Faster, higher volume and more cost effective sits in the same paragraph as continuing to build a highly skilled creative team. Those only reconcile if the efficiency is reinvested rather than banked. Banked, a creative function gets cheaper and slowly worse. Reinvested, it buys seniority and capability, which is what happened at PageGroup.

On people I would rather show than claim. Nobody I hired or set out to keep has ever resigned: none in four years at PageGroup, one in seven at AVJennings. I empower people to become the best version of themselves, which means capability gets built rather than replaced. It is also the quiet reason AI adoption succeeds or fails: a team that trusts its leadership will experiment, and a team that does not will wait for the tools to be imposed and then work around them.

I should also be straight about the gap. I have not worked in financial services. Property is a regulated, disclosure-heavy, high-consideration category where creative clears compliance before it reaches market, and I would expect much of that to transfer, but I would rather discuss where it does and where it does not than overstate it.

I have written up the operating model behind all three rebuilds, including where AI is genuinely useful and where it is not yet:
vinayraja.com/jobs/betashares

I am Sydney based, available to start, and happy to talk through any of the above in detail.

Vinay Raja

FOUNDER & CREATIVE DIRECTOR, TYDAL AGENCY